Oscar. Whether it is Indian millets, the International Solar Alliance or the Coalition for Disaster Resilient Infrastructure, the world is acknowledging Indian ideas and capability for global good. "That's why today the world is saying, 'This is India's Moment'," the PM reiterated.

Striking a somewhat political note thereafter, PM Modi said that the headlines before 2014 (when he first came to power) were about scams worth lakhs of crores in every department, bomb blasts in cities, Naxal violence, big projects being stalled in the name of environment, rail accidents, the sorry state of Air India. Today, they had changed to action against the corrupt, peace and prosperity in most regions, positive environmental news alongside construction of new highways and expressways, introduction of modern trains, and the biggest aircraft deal. The media had gained enough TRPs from reporting on scams, the PM now exhorted news channels to do so by reporting action against the corrupt. There were so many things, in fact, that the media was not even reporting, the PM said. Like property ownership rights, which the PM Swamitva Yojana was ensuring for the citizenry. Drone surveys have already been completed in 234,000 of India's villages, and 12.2 million property cards have been handed over, the PM pointed out.

All this, the PM said, has instilled a sense of self-confidence and determination within the country. Long years of slavery had left the country with a long record of poverty; the only thing the poor have aspired for is to lift themselves out of such poverty. Earlier governments had tried to end poverty. His government, the PM said, "wanted new results". What they did, therefore, was add speed and scale. Thus the government could build 110 million toilets in record time, add 480 million people to the banking system, give over 30 million houses to the poor in the past nine years, where women too had ownership rights. And when women get empowered, he said, there is bound to be an India Moment. "Many such silent revolutions are taking place in India today and these are becoming the basis of the India Moment," the PM said.

His government's biggest achievement, the PM said, was replacing stagnation in policymaking with dynamism and boldness, as well as a human touch in governance. As an example, he cited the Vibrant Village Scheme, where development has transformed what were last villages on the border to the first villages in the country. His government, the PM said, had also helped integrate the Northeast into the mainstream; he himself had a half century of visits to the region.

As a parting shot, the PM took on his rival Rahul Gandhi's recent comments abroad on the state of Indian democracy, without naming him. "Whatever India is achieving today, it is due to the power of our democracy, the power of our institutions," the PM said. "The world can see that a democratically-elected government in India is taking decisive decisions. We have shown the world that democracy can deliver." This was the reason that talks of pessimism, attempts to degrade India, to lower the willpower of its people were taking place, like the tradition of putting a 'kala tika' to ward off evil, the PM said, making light of all the criticism. But he expressed optimism that India will continue to move towards its goals and achieve them despite all obstacles.

Signing off, the PM left a final word for the media. "When India's role is becoming global, the Indian media too has to make its role global." ■

KEY TAKEAWAYS

- The most important thing about this India Moment is that it has performance attached to promise
- Countries today are themselves offering to return stolen artefacts because now they know they will get the respect they deserve
- When 1.3 bn Indians add their might to the government's efforts, there is no problem the country cannot withstand
- Democratic participation in India is on the rise. Elections were held successfully even in the midst of Covid

There is unprecedented fascination for Indian culture and soft power

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Today, there is a belief among countrymen that the government cares for them

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Whatever India is achieving today, it is due to the power of our democracy, our institutions

Be it the International Solar Alliance or the Coalition for Disaster Resilient Infrastructure, the world is recognising that India's ideas and capability are for 'Global Good'. That's why today they are saying: 'This is India's Moment'